



Call for Applications: Research Associate

Based in Patna | Multiple research projects across Bihar | Start - Oct 15, 2026 | Apply by Sept 21, 2026

www.gramagovernance.com

Research Associate, GRAMA - Bihar Local Governance

M. R. Sharan (**University of Maryland**), Siddharth George (**National University of Singapore**), Siddharth Hari (**World Bank**), Apurva Bamezai (**Ashoka University**), and Nandini Gupta (**University of Oxford**) are hiring a Research Associate to join GRAMA, a research team studying rural local governance, citizen voices, and public service delivery in Bihar.

GRAMA is a research and policy initiative working to strengthen the accountability of public institutions. It does this by centring the perspectives of those such institutions are meant to serve last-mile citizens, the frontline workers who connect them to the state, and the local elected officials who represent them. The Research Associate will work across the full arc of a research project - from an RCT on peer learning among local leaders in JEEViKA, Bihar, to translating the results for policymakers, and eventually seeing how those results shape policy.

Previous RAs have gone on to PhD programs at Harvard (Econ), Oxford (Econ), University of Chicago (Econ), Yale (Poli Sci), University of British Columbia (Econ), Stanford GSB (Econ), Columbia (Econ), UC Davis (Econ), UC Irvine (Econ), and Imperial (Econ); and pursued pre-docs at Oxford, Princeton, and Harvard.

GRAMA's work

Most policy is actually implemented in panchayats, block offices, and district administrations. Yet local governance remains one of the least understood parts of the Indian state. This is a chance to study it up close: survey data one day, a conversation with a block- or district-level official the next. The work involves watching, first-hand, how decisions move - or stall - between Bihar's government departments and the citizens they are meant to reach.

GRAMA is being built from the ground up, and this hire will be part of the core group deciding how it runs: which questions it asks, which officials it engages, and how its findings actually reach the people making policy. This is an opportunity to understand not just what rigorous governance research looks like, but how academics and policymakers can genuinely work together.

KEY RESPONSIBILITIES

- Designing survey questionnaires and refining surveying instruments.
- Planning and managing data collection and ensuring data quality and productivity.
- Managing field teams which includes but not limited to recruit, train, and supervise both field-based and data operations teams consisting of project assistants, field managers, field-based surveyors, and other field and office staff.
- Assisting with data cleaning, preliminary data analysis, and preparation of documents and presentations for dissemination.



- Engage directly with government stakeholders - from block-level functionaries to senior state officials - to support fieldwork, data access, and dissemination of findings
- Assist with econometric analysis and the preparation of tables, figures, and policy briefs
- Contribute to academic papers, policy notes, and presentations for scholarly and government audiences
- Reporting to PIs and Research Manager on all of the aforementioned activities.

REQUIRED SKILLS AND QUALIFICATIONS

- Master's or a strong Undergraduate degree in Economics, Political Science, Public Policy, Data Science, or a related field
- Strong data skills - well-versed in Stata and/or R; working knowledge of Python is a bonus
- Familiarity with modern applied econometric methods
- Strong analytical writing is a bonus
- Knowledge of SurveyCTO/ODK/digital data collection (preferred).
- Comfortable liaising with a wide range of stakeholders, including senior government officials and academics
- Attention to detail and advanced writing and presentation skills for communicating with multiple partners. This requires the ability to produce clear, precise, non-technical writing as well as strong social skills.
- Willingness to travel within Bihar, including extended stints in the field, and to independently run on-the-ground research operations
- At least one year of prior research experience preferred
- Working proficiency in English and Hindi
- Ability to give and receive completely frank feedback.
- Interest in development and policy-research.

WHAT YOU'LL GET

- A clear path to co-authorship on research papers
- Close mentorship from people at Maryland, NUS, Oxford, Ashoka and the World Bank
- A front-row seat to how state government actually functions - and where rigorous research can genuinely shift policy
- Strong preparation for PhD programs and pre-doctoral research positions

TIMELINE AND REMUNERATION

Start Date	October 15, 2026 - sooner the better
Duration	1 year (extendable)
Compensation	Competitive, commensurate with experience

HOW TO APPLY

Applications are reviewed on a rolling basis - early applications are encouraged. To apply, please put together your resume, a cover letter, and a writing sample, and submit via the [application form link](#).

Applications received after **September 21, 2026** may not be considered. Applicants from disadvantaged backgrounds and local candidates from Bihar are especially encouraged to apply. This position requires valid work authorization in India.



Applicants should not reach out to the faculty directly.

Note: Due to the volume of applications we receive, we are unable to contact each candidate individually regarding the status of their application. Only shortlisted applicants will be contacted for interviews.

Last but not least, if you know your way around Catan and other indoor games, you're already off to a good start.

www.gramagovernance.com

GRAMA - Governance Research & Accountability for Meaningful Advancement · Patna, Bihar